A MESSAGE TO EVERY MUSLIM STRUGGLING IN THIS GENERATION

Based on Surah Al-Kahf — The Story of the People of the Cave

Lectures by Hisham Abu Yusuf | Al-Furqan Islamic Centre, Manchester

---

> *"We relate to you their story in truth. They were young men who believed in their Lord, and We increased them in guidance."* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:13)

OPENING — LET ME ASK YOU SOMETHING

Before we begin — let me ask you an honest question.

When was the last time you felt the pressure? Not a dramatic, cinematic kind of pressure. Not someone holding a sword to your throat demanding you abandon your faith. That kind of pressure is real — and throughout history, many Muslims have faced it. But that is not what most of us deal with today.

The pressure most of us face is quieter than that. More subtle. More suffocating.

It is the pressure of walking into a room and being the only one who does not drink. The pressure of explaining — again — why you cannot make it to that event on Friday afternoon. The pressure of being the only one in your friend group who actually prays. The pressure of feeling like your values make you strange, rigid, out of touch. Like you are permanently swimming against a current that everyone else seems happy to float with.

That pressure — the pressure of the crowd, the pressure of the environment, the pressure of simply being different in a world that punishes difference — that is the real test of this generation.

And Allah Subhanahu Wa Ta'ala knew this test was coming. Not just for us — but for every generation of believers who would find themselves as a minority in a world that did not share their values. And so He preserved, in His eternal Book, a story specifically for this moment. A story told in precise detail, with lessons so practical and so vivid that they feel as though they were revealed yesterday.

The story of **Ashab Al-Kahf** — the People of the Cave.

PART ONE: SEVEN YOUNG MEN, ONE IMPOSSIBLE SITUATION

Imagine the scene.

A city in the ancient world. A king on the throne who has declared that there is one acceptable way to live — and it is not the way of monotheism. The society around you worships idols, lives by values that contradict everything you believe, and has made very clear what happens to those who refuse to conform.

In the middle of this city live a small group of young men. We do not know exactly how many — seven is the most widely cited number, though Allah Himself does not confirm the exact count, and we will come back to why that is significant. What we know is that they are young. And they believe in Allah with a certainty that their entire environment is trying to crush.

Now think about what it means to be young in that situation.

Youth is not a time of settled certainty. It is a time of energy, distraction, temptation, and an overwhelming need to belong. Every young person wants to be accepted. Every young person feels the pull of the crowd. The desire to fit in is not weakness — it is a natural human instinct, and it is especially powerful in youth.

And yet these young men — in the middle of all of that — held firm.

This is why, when Allah introduces them in the Quran, He does something He almost never does. He breaks His own pattern.

When Allah introduces believers elsewhere in the Quran, He typically leads with their faith: *"They were believers who..."* Faith is always mentioned first. It is the primary quality. Everything else is secondary.

But here, He reverses the order:

ARABIC:

> نَّحْنُ نَقُصُّ عَلَيْكَ نَبَأَهُم بِالْحَقِّ ۚ إِنَّهُمْ فِتْيَةٌ آمَنُوا بِرَبِّهِمْ وَزِدْنَاهُمْ هُدًى

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Nahnu naqussu alayka naba'ahum bilhaqq. Innahum fityatun aamanoo birabbihim wa zidnaahum hudaa."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"We relate to you their story in truth. They were young men who believed in their Lord, and We increased them in guidance."* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:13)

Young men first. Believers second.

Allah led with their youth before their faith. And this is not an accident. Nothing in the Quran is an accident. Allah is telling us — from the very first description — what makes this story remarkable. It is not simply that they believed. It is that they believed *at their age, in their circumstances, under that kind of pressure.*

Whoever begins to take effort towards Allah — despite whatever surrounds them — Allah is going to make things easy for them.

That is the first promise embedded in this story. And it sets the stage for everything that follows.

PART TWO: THE PRESSURE THEY FACED — AND THE LIE THEY REFUSED

So what exactly were these young men up against?

They lived in a pagan society — a society that did not worship Allah, did not live by the values of justice and monotheism, and actively promoted a way of life that contradicted everything they stood for. They were not just a minority. They were a minority within a minority. The extreme edge. The ones nobody understood.

And then there was the king.

This was not a benign ruler who simply disagreed with them. This was a tyrant who demanded religious conformity, and who made the consequences of non-conformity very clear. Allah records those consequences directly in the Quran:

ARABIC:

> إِنَّهُمْ إِن يَظْهَرُوا عَلَيْكُمْ يَرْجُمُوكُمْ أَوْ يُعِيدُوكُمْ فِي مِلَّتِهِمْ وَلَن تُفْلِحُوا إِذًا أَبَدًا

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Innahum in yazharoo alaykum yarjumookum aw yu'eedookum fee millatihim wa lan*

> *tuflihooo idhan abada."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"Indeed, if they come upon you, they will stone you or return you to their religion. And you would never succeed then — ever."* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:20)

Two options if discovered. Death. Or forced apostasy. That was the reality they were navigating.

But beyond the political threat — which was real and terrifying — there was something even more insidious at work. Something that did not require a king or a law or a punishment to be effective. Something that works silently, every single day, on every young person living as a minority.

The lie of the crowd.

"Everybody is doing this." "Are you going to be the only one who doesn't?" "Why are you making life so hard for yourself?" "Nobody actually follows all those rules anymore." "You're going to miss out." "Just this once."

This is the deception that has been given to every generation of young believers since the beginning of time. The message is always the same, even when the words change: *you are strange, you are rigid, you are alone, and you would be much happier if you just went with the flow.*

Young people are particularly vulnerable to this because the environment shapes you whether you choose to be shaped or not. If you do not actively resist, the current takes you. You do not even notice it happening — until one day you look back and realize you have drifted very far from where you started.

These young men saw this trap clearly. And they did not step into it.

They did not gulp the lie. They did not negotiate. They did not meet the crowd halfway.

Instead, they made a decision that changed everything.

PART THREE: BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE — THEY HAD EACH OTHER

Here is something that gets overlooked when people tell this story.

Before the cave. Before the planning. Before the stand in front of the king. Before any of the

famous elements of the story that we talk about — these young men had each other.

They were together. United. A small group of believers in the middle of a sea of disbelief — and they held onto each other.

This is not a small detail. This is foundational. Because one of the most important questions any young Muslim must ask themselves is not just *"What do I believe?"* but *"Who do I spend my time with?"*

The people around you are not neutral. They are either pulling you toward Allah or pulling you away. There is no standing still. Your environment shapes you — and your closest companions are the most powerful part of your environment.

Allah gives us a direct instruction about this from the very story of the cave:

ARABIC:

> **وَاصْبِرْ نَفْسَكَ مَعَ الَّذِينَ يَدْعُونَ رَبَّهُم بِالْغَدَاةِ وَالْعَشِيِّ يُرِيدُونَ وَجْهَهُۖ وَلَا تَعْدُ عَيْنَاكَ عَنْهُمْ تُرِيدُ زِينَةَ الْحَيَاةِ الدُّنْيَا**

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Wasbir nafsaka ma'alladhina yad'oona rabbahum bilghadaati wal'ashiyyi yureedoona wajhah. Wa laa ta'du aynaaka anhum tureedu zeenatal hayaatid dunya."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"And keep yourself patient with those who call upon their Lord morning and afternoon, seeking His face. And do not let your eyes look away from them, desiring the adornments of worldly life."* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:28)

Notice what Allah says here. He does not just say *find good company.* He says **be patient** in maintaining it — because good company is not always easy to find, and it is not always easy to keep. It requires effort. It requires persistence. It requires actively choosing it again and again even when the alternative is more convenient or more fun.

And then He adds something remarkable: **"Do not let your eyes look away from them."**

Not just: find them. **Keep your gaze on them.** Because there are a thousand things trying to pull your gaze away — your phone, entertainment, gossip, people who seem more exciting, more social, more interesting. The distractions of this world are designed to make you look away from the people who are genuinely good for you.

So the practical advice is not complicated:

Be patient and persistent in finding people whose only goal in life is to see the face of Allah. Send out a search party. Go knock on doors. And when you find such people — make them your closest friends, and do not let them go.

The Problem of Friends by Accident

But here is the honest reality of how most of us end up with the friends we have.

We did not choose them. Not really. We ended up in a friendship group by accident — by proximity, by repetition, by the slow accumulation of shared time without any shared intention.

You saw the same person at school every day. You worked next to them. You kept bumping into them at the same tea shop. And gradually, without any conscious decision, they became your companion. Your closest circle.

Friends by chance. Companions by accident.

And Allah is saying: you cannot afford that. Not in this climate. Not when the environment is working so hard against your values every single day. You have to choose your friends the way you choose everything else that matters — **deliberately, carefully, and with full awareness of what is at stake.**

Because the wrong company does not destroy you all at once. It does it slowly. Quietly. In the small compromises that seem harmless in the moment — the gathering you went to even though you knew it was not right for you, the conversation you stayed in even though it was pulling you somewhere you did not want to go, the habit you picked up because everyone around you had it.

Allah warns about this friendship in the most serious possible terms — not just in this life, but on the Day of Judgment:

ARABIC:

> الْأَخِلَّاءُ يَوْمَئِذٍ بَعْضُهُمْ لِبَعْضٍ عَدُوٌّ إِلَّا الْمُتَّقِينَ

TRANSLITERATION:

> *“Al-akhillaau yawma’idhin ba’duhum liba’din ‘aduwwun illal muttaqeen.”*

TRANSLATION:

> *“Close friends on that Day will be enemies to each other — except for the righteous.” —*

> Surah Az-Zukhruf (43:67)

The friends who pulled you away from Allah will become your enemies on the Day of Judgment. You will blame each other for the mutual destruction. The friendship that felt so comfortable, so easy, so natural — will be the thing you regret most deeply on that Day.

Only the friendships built on the foundation of Allah — where both people were trying to reach Him together — will survive that Day intact.

Choose now who you want standing next to you then.

PART FOUR: STOP ARGUING ABOUT THE WRONG THINGS

Now — before we go further into the story — Allah does something unexpected.

Right in the middle of telling us about the cave, He pauses and points out a mistake. Not a mistake the young men made. A mistake that *we* make when we engage with this story. And with the Quran in general.

People argue about how many young men were in the cave. Three? Five? Seven? And each group is absolutely certain they are right.

ARABIC:

> سَيَقُولُونَ ثَلَاثَةٌ رَّابِعُهُمْ كَلْبُهُمْ وَيَقُولُونَ خَمْسَةٌ سَادِسُهُمْ كَلْبُهُمْ رَجْمًا بِالْغَيْبِ ۖ وَيَقُولُونَ سَبْعَةٌ وَثَامِنُهُمْ كَلْبُهُمْ

TRANSLITERATION:

> *“Sayaqooloona thalaathatun raabi’uhum kalbuhum wa yaqooloona khamsatun saadisuhum kalbuhum rajman bilghayb. Wa yaqooloona sab’atun wa thaminuhum kalbuhum.”*

TRANSLATION:

> *“Some will say they were three, the fourth being their dog. And some will say they were five, the sixth being their dog — guessing about the unseen. And some will say they were seven, and the eighth was their dog.”* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:22)

And then Allah gives His response:

ARABIC:

> قُل رَّبِّي أَعْلَمُ بِعِدَّتِهِمْ مَّا يَعْلَمُهُمْ إِلَّا قَلِيلٌ فَلَا تُمَارِ فِيهِمْ إِلَّا مِرَاءً ظَاهِرًا وَلَا تَسْتَفْتِ فِيهِم مِّنْهُمْ أَحَدًا

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Qul rabbee a'lamu bi'iddatihim. Maa ya'lamuhum illaa qaleel. Falaa tumaari feehim illaa miraa'an zaahiran wa laa tastafti feehim minhum ahada."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"Say: My Lord knows best their number. None know them except a few. So do not argue about them except with a clear argument, and do not inquire about them from anyone."*
> — Surah Al-Kahf (18:22)

Allah is saying this bluntly: **this is not what matters. Stop arguing about it. Move on.**

Think about what throwing stones in the dark looks like. You are in a pitch-black room. There is a target somewhere in front of you. You start throwing. No matter how hard you throw — you will miss every time, because you cannot see where you are aiming. You have no real knowledge of where the target is. You are just swinging blindly and hoping.

This is what happens when we debate detailed matters that we have no real knowledge of and that are not central to our practice. We miss the target every time. We exhaust our energy on darkness and miss the light that is right in front of us.

And the tragedy is — look at the questions being debated today compared to the questions the Companions of the Prophet ﷺ asked.

Today, someone calls a scholar on television: *"Can I trim my eyebrows?"* Another asks about a specific ingredient in a packet of sweets. Another about parking. These are not bad questions — but they reveal a priorities problem. The center has been lost. The peripheral has taken over.

The Companions asked differently. Someone would come to the Prophet ﷺ and say:

"Oh Prophet of Allah — tell me a way that Allah can love me and I can love Him."

"Tell me a way I can enter paradise and escape the hellfire."

Deep questions. Akhirah questions. Questions about the core of the relationship with Allah.

This is the second lesson of the cave story, and it comes before the practical lessons about

what to do — because if you do not get your priorities right first, none of the practical steps will matter. You will spend your energy debating how many young men were in the cave while your own cave collapses around you.

Focus on what matters. Let the small things go.

PART FIVE: THE QURAN IS NOT A BOOK OF MELODIES

With that foundation in place — the right company, the right priorities — Allah gives us the first of His key practical lessons from the story of the cave.

He commands the Prophet ﷺ:

ARABIC:

> وَاتْلُ مَا أُوحِيَ إِلَيْكَ مِن كِتَابِ رَبِّكَ ۖ لَا مُبَدِّلَ لِكَلِمَاتِهِ وَلَن تَجِدَ مِن دُونِهِ مُلْتَحَدًا

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Watlu maa oohiya ilayka min kitaabi rabbik. Laa mubaddila likalimatihi wa lan tajida min doonihi multahada."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"Recite what has been revealed to you of the Book of your Lord. None can change His words, and you will find no refuge other than Him."* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:27)

The command is: **utlu** — from the word *tilawa*.

We use this word every day. We think it means recitation — reading the Quran in a beautiful voice, completing it in Ramadan, playing it in the car. And we have reduced its meaning to exactly that.

But in the original Arabic, *tala* means **to follow something.** To track it. To go behind it. The way you follow a road. The way you follow a guide.

Tilawa originally means to follow the Quran in action. Recitation was always meant to be the first step — the starting point — not the destination. You read it so that you can follow it. You recite it so that it changes how you live.

But somewhere along the way, we made the step the destination. We satisfied ourselves with the beautiful recitation and stopped there. We never arrived at the actual goal.

Imagine a footballer who trains for months. Gets completely fit. Learns all the techniques. Knows every rule of the game. And then on match day, walks onto the pitch, dribbles the ball to the edge of the penalty box — and stops. Does not shoot. Just turns around and walks back to the changing room.

You walked all the way there. You did everything right up to the last moment. And you stopped before the goal.

This is what we have done with the Quran. We learned the Arabic letters — alhamdulillah. We learned to recite — beautiful. We taught our children to complete the Quran — a great achievement. And then we stopped. We never got to the goal. We never arrived at what the Quran is actually supposed to do — which is change the way we live.

Allah says there were nations before us who made this same mistake. They recited their scriptures beautifully. They sang their hymns. They knew the chapters. But in their buying and selling, their marriages, their business dealings, their treatment of people — the scripture had no bearing whatsoever. It was a book of songs. A decoration on the shelf. A nice sound in the car.

And it did not change them.

We are at risk of becoming the same. And the solution starts at home.

The Greatest Weapon You Can Give Your Child

If you want your children to survive — to have their identity intact, their values clear, their cave protected — the first and most powerful thing you can give them is **an understood, living relationship with the Quran.**

Not just recitation. Understanding. Not just the Arabic letters — the meanings.

Yes, teach them to recite. That is the foundation, and it is important. But do not stop halfway. Do not walk to the edge of the penalty box and turn around.

When your child is seven years old — when they can think, ask questions, and understand stories — start talking to them about the meanings of the suras. You do not need an Islamic degree. You need to make it a story. Add characters. Add drama. Make it vivid. A seven-year-old hearing the story of the cave — the young men, the king, the escape in the night, the sun moving around them while they slept for hundreds of years — will be completely captivated.

When they are fourteen or fifteen — go deeper. Open Al-Baqarah with them. Discuss what Allah is actually saying. Ask them questions. Let them discover it.

And here is the honest, perhaps uncomfortable truth: **your child's madrasa teacher is not going to do this.** The supplementary Quran school system is built almost entirely around

recitation. The Imam is not going to come to your house on Sunday afternoon and explain Surah Al-Kahf to your thirteen-year-old.

You have to do this. Because children do not primarily learn by listening to lectures. They watch. They imitate. They absorb from the atmosphere of the home. If the Quran is alive in you — if you pick it up, if you talk about it naturally, if it visibly affects the decisions you make — your child will feel that before they can articulate it. And it will take root in them in a way that no classroom can replicate.

The greatest weapon you can place in the hands of the next generation is not a degree, not a skill, not a career — it is an understanding of what is inside the Book of Allah.

PART SIX: THE DECISION — FINDING YOUR CAVE

Now we come back to the young men.

They have looked at their situation clearly. They know what the environment is asking of them — to conform, to assimilate, to abandon their values quietly and blend in. They know what happens if they refuse — death or forced apostasy. They know the crowd is against them. They know the king is against them.

And they make a decision.

Not to fight. Not to negotiate. Not to find some middle ground between their faith and the demands of the world around them.

They decide to find a cave.

ARABIC:

> وَإِذِ اعْتَزَلْتُمُوهُمْ وَمَا يَعْبُدُونَ إِلَّا اللَّهَ فَأْوُوا إِلَى الْكَهْفِ يَنشُرْ لَكُمْ رَبُّكُم مِّن رَّحْمَتِهِ وَيُهَيِّئْ لَكُم مِّنْ أَمْرِكُم مِّرفَقًا

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Wa idhit tazaltumoohumuu wa maa ya'budoona illallaha fa'woo ilal kahfi yanshur lakum rabbukum min rahmatih wa yuhayyi' lakum min amrikum mirfaqa."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"And when you have withdrawn from them and what they worship other than Allah — take refuge in the cave. Your Lord will spread out for you from His mercy and will prepare for you from your affair ease."* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:16)

And the moment they arrive at that cave — before they sleep, before they rest, before they do anything else — they raise their hands and they make dua:

ARABIC:

> إِذْ أَوَى الْفِتْيَةُ إِلَى الْكَهْفِ فَقَالُوا رَبَّنَا آتِنَا مِن لَّدُنكَ رَحْمَةً وَهَيِّئْ لَنَا مِنْ أَمْرِنَا رَشَدًا

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Idh awal fityatu ilal kahfi faqaaloo rabbana aatina min ladunka rahmatan wa hayyi' lana min amrina rashada."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"When the young men took refuge in the cave and said: Our Lord, grant us mercy from Yourself and prepare for us from our affair right guidance."* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:10)

"Our Lord — we have done everything we can. We have planned. We have moved. We have left everything familiar behind. Now — grant us mercy from Yourself. Because if You do not will it, none of this will matter."

This moment is everything. They did not say: *"We are safe now. We handled it."* They said: *"We need You. We do not know exactly where this road leads. Guide us."*

This is the complete model that the cave teaches us: act with full effort, then surrender with full trust.

Not action without trust. Not trust without action. Both — always both.

What Is Your Cave?

People in many Western countries look at Muslim communities and say: you are not integrating. You have your own mosques, your own schools, your own communities. You are separate.

And one teacher responded to this with a question so simple it stops the entire argument:

"Why would I integrate into something that is disintegrating? Why would I join something that is breaking apart?"

Look at what is being asked of us to integrate into. One in three young girls self-harming due to depression and anxiety. One in three elderly people dying of loneliness. Families

fractured. Mental health at epidemic levels. Addiction. Meaninglessness. A culture that offers everything except peace.

Why would any sensible person abandon a community, a value system, and a way of life that provides meaning, structure, purpose, and belonging — to dissolve into something that is visibly falling apart at the seams?

We would not integrate. We would set up something better — and allow our children to live on those values.

The cave is not isolation. The cave is the protected space where you can be fully Muslim without apology:

- Your **masjid** — the community that keeps you grounded
- Your **Islamic school** — where your children's identity is reinforced rather than eroded
- Your **righteous circle of friends** — who push you toward Allah
- Your **home** — where the Quran is discussed, not just displayed

These are your cave. And you have to build them — because nobody else will.

PART SEVEN: UNITY IS NOT OPTIONAL

When you have a terrible environment — when the pressure is constant, when everything around you contradicts your values, when staying on the straight path takes daily, exhausting effort — you do not have the luxury of being divided.

Division is a luxury of the comfortable.

When life is easy, when your identity is not under threat, when the environment is not hostile — perhaps you can afford the luxury of internal disagreement. You have minor theological differences. You debate the small things. You argue about how to fold your hands in prayer.

But when you are the minority of the minority — when the environment itself is trying to erase you — spending your energy fighting each other is not just wasteful. **It is suicidal.**

Look at what happens to Muslim communities during moments of intense external pressure. Muslims who normally argue about which madhab is correct suddenly unite. Because they realize: there is a bigger problem at stake. Let us focus on this.

The moment you allow internal division to take hold in a pressuring environment — you will break. And when you break, you lose the younger generation. They will look at the adults around them fighting over small things while the larger identity collapses, and they will

simply walk away.

ARABIC:

> وَاعْتَصِمُوا بِحَبْلِ اللَّهِ جَمِيعًا وَلَا تَفَرَّقُوا

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Wa'tasimoo bihablillahi jamee'an wa laa tafarraqoo."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"And hold firmly to the rope of Allah all together and do not become divided."* — Surah Aal-Imran (3:103)

Hold together. Plan together. Build together. Because the cave that protected seven people from all the disbelief around them did not work because they were seven individuals each doing their own thing. It worked because they were **one unified body** with one shared direction.

PART EIGHT: TRUST IN ALLAH DOES NOT MEAN DO NOTHING

Now — a dangerous misunderstanding that costs the Muslim community enormously, and that the story of the cave corrects directly.

Many Muslims use the phrase *"I trust Allah"* as an excuse not to plan, not to think strategically, not to act. This is not tawakkul. This is laziness wrapped in religious language — and it is an insult to one of the most beautiful concepts in Islam.

The example is almost comical: someone parks their car on double yellow lines. They are told it is illegal. They say: *"Brother, this is Allah. Tawakkul."*

Someone wakes up with no job and no income and says: *"Maybe a bird will come and drop the money on my doorstep. I trust Allah."*

No. This is not what tawakkul means.

True tawakkul means: you take every means available to you, plan with full intelligence and effort — and then trust Allah for what is beyond your control.

Tawakkul is not the beginning of the process. It is the end. It is what you do after you have done everything within your human capacity. You plan first. You act first. And then — and

only then — you trust.

Look at how the young men in the cave actually operated. After reaching safety, when they need to send someone to the city for food, this is the instruction they give:

ARABIC:

> فَابْعَثُوا أَحَدَكُم بِوَرِقِكُمْ هَٰذِهِ إِلَى الْمَدِينَةِ فَلْيَنظُرْ أَيُّهَا أَزْكَىٰ طَعَامًا فَلْيَأْتِكُم بِرِزْقٍ مِّنْهُ وَلْيَتَلَطَّفْ وَلَا يُشْعِرَنَّ بِكُمْ أَحَدًا

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Fab'athoo ahadakum biwariqikum hadhihi ilal madeenati falyandur ayyuha azka ta'aman falyatikum birizqin minhu walyatalattaf wa laa yush'iranna bikum ahada."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"So send one of you with this silver coin to the city and let him see which food is purest and bring you provision from it. And let him be careful — and let no one be aware of you."* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:19)

One person — not a group that attracts attention. Silver coin ready — they planned financially. Be careful, be alert, be cautious. Let no one know where you are going or where you came from.

These are the instructions of people who planned meticulously. Who were fully aware of their surroundings, of the consequences of every action, of the importance of every detail. And after all that planning — they made dua and trusted Allah completely.

This is the model. **Plan thoroughly. Act wisely. Trust completely.**

Young Muslims today need this same awareness. Know your political environment. Know the laws. Know the social landscape. Understand what is happening around you so you can navigate it with wisdom — not stumble through it blind and call that tawakkul.

PART NINE: THE STAND — NO COMPROMISE, NO NEGOTIATION

But before the cave — before the escape — there was a moment that defined who these young men truly were.

They stood in front of the king. In public. In the court. In front of everyone who had the power to destroy them.

And they said:

ARABIC:

> رَبُّنَا رَبُّ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ لَن نَّدْعُوَ مِن دُونِهِ إِلَٰهًا ۖ لَّقَدْ قُلْنَا إِذًا شَطَطًا

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Rabbuna rabbus samaawaati wal ardi lan nad'uwa min doonihi ilaahan laqad qulna idhan shatata."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"Our Lord is the Lord of the heavens and the earth. We will never call upon any god other than Him. If we did, we would have said something extremely wrong."* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:14)

No softening. No diplomatic hedging. No trying to make their faith sound palatable to those in power.

They did not say: *"Well — Islam is a religion of peace. We respect all traditions. We can find common ground."*

They said: **Our Lord is the Lord of the heavens and the earth. We will NEVER worship other than Him. And if we did — that would be the greatest lie imaginable.**

The Prophet ﷺ told us:

> *"The greatest jihad is to speak a word of truth to a tyrannical ruler."* — Sunan Abu Dawud (4344)

These young men embodied this. In the most dangerous moment, in front of the most powerful person in their world — they spoke with absolute clarity.

This is what confidence looks like. Not arrogance. Not aggression. Just settled, unshakeable clarity about who you are and Whose you are.

And here is the thing about compromise: it never ends where it starts.

The pressure comes. And you think — let me be reasonable. Let me meet them halfway. *"I cannot pray five times a day right now — I will pray twice. That is still something, right?"*

And the pressure comes again. Twice becomes once. Once becomes Jumu'ah only. Jumu'ah becomes Eid only. Eid becomes nothing.

The middle ground keeps moving. Once you put your values on the negotiating table — you have already begun to lose them.

"Jumu'ah? No way. My prayer? No way. You can bring whoever you want. But the King of all kings is on my side."

This is the mindset. Not negotiation. Not compromise. A clear line — and the settled confidence to stand behind it.

PART TEN: THE HIDDEN PROTECTOR — ALLAH AS AL-WALI

When Allah describes the efforts of these young men — their unity, their stand, their escape, their dua in the cave — He pauses to mention something about Himself. Two of His beautiful names. And one of them deserves our full attention:

Al-Wali — الْوَلِيُّ

The Protective Guardian. The Close Ally. The Hidden Protector.

ARABIC:

> قُلْ إِنَّ وَلِيِّيَ اللَّهُ الَّذِي نَزَّلَ الْكِتَابَ ۖ وَهُوَ يَتَوَلَّى الصَّالِحِينَ

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Qul inna waliyyiyallaahu alladhee nazzalal kitaaba wa huwa yatawallas saaliheen."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"Say: Indeed, my protector is Allah who has sent down the Book. And He is an ally to the righteous."* — Surah Al-A'raf (7:196)

Think about what protection actually looks like at its most powerful.

When a prime minister walks into a room, you can see the bodyguards. They are big, imposing, visible — designed to terrify anyone who comes close. That is one kind of protection.

But there is another kind — far more sophisticated, and far more complete. The hidden

protection. The bodyguards in plain clothes who you never notice. The vehicle following at a distance. The person on the rooftop you cannot see. The perimeter that exists all around the protected person — and that they themselves are often not even aware of.

This is how Allah protects the righteous.

You will not always see it. You will not always feel it. You will go through difficult days and wonder where the protection is. But the evidence shows up — sometimes dramatically, sometimes quietly — in the shape of your life:

A brick is thrown at your head. It misses by an inch. A lorry loses control on the motorway and hits four cars. Yours is untouched. Your child steps into the road and a car narrowly misses them. Your entire department is made redundant. Everyone loses their job. Except you.

What is this? This is Allah. Your protector. Working in ways you did not plan for and cannot engineer. When everybody is against you — you have this. But only if you take the path that leads to it.

Be from the righteous. And you will have a force field around you that no human power can penetrate.

Yusuf in the Well. Musa in the Desert.

Do you think Yusuf (AS) — sitting at the bottom of a dark well, abandoned by his own brothers, with no food and no way out — do you think he realized that Allah was planning for him to be in the palace of the king of Egypt?

Do you think Musa (AS) — running barefoot through the scorching desert, alone, a fugitive with nothing — do you think he realized that Allah was planning to give him a job, a wife, a purpose, and bring him back as a Prophet?

They did not know. They could not have imagined it.

But Allah was working while they suffered. The very place that looked like a dead end — the well, the desert, the cave — was the corridor to the destination Allah had already chosen.

When you have no helpers. When you have no protectors. When you are completely alone and have nobody to turn to — turn to Al-Wali.

Because whoever takes Allah as their closest companion discovers something extraordinary:

Your lonely cave will become the brightest place. Your dark well will become the most enjoyable place.

Not because the circumstances changed. But because you have the company of Allah when you have nobody else's company.

And here is the truth that the entire lecture has been building toward:

> **If you lost Allah in your life, you have nothing. But if you found Allah, you have everything.**

Everything else — the friends, the cave, the planning, the standing firm, the building of institutions — all of it is a path that leads to this one reality. A direct, living, trusting relationship with Allah Subhanahu Wa Ta'ala. That is the destination. That is what the People of the Cave had. That is what made all the difference.

PART ELEVEN: THE PROMISE — IT WILL ALWAYS COME TRUE

When the young men went to sleep in the cave, they did not know what was coming. They may have hoped the laws would change, the king would die, someone would rescue them. They planned what they could plan — and then they surrendered what they could not control to Allah.

What Allah actually did: He put them to sleep for three hundred and nine years.

They never expected that.

ARABIC:

> وَكَذَٰلِكَ أَعْثَرْنَا عَلَيْهِمْ لِيَعْلَمُوا أَنَّ وَعْدَ اللَّهِ حَقٌّ وَأَنَّ السَّاعَةَ لَا رَيْبَ فِيهَا

TRANSLITERATION:

> *"Wa kadhaalika a'tharna alayhim liya'lamoo anna wa'dallahi haqqun wa annas saa'ata laa rayba feehaa."*

TRANSLATION:

> *"And thus We caused them to be found so that they would know that the promise of Allah is truth, and that the Hour — there is no doubt about it."* — Surah Al-Kahf (18:21)

This is why Allah did all of it. Not just for the young men — but for everyone who would ever read this story until the end of time. **So that we would know: the promise of Allah always comes true.**

It may take three seconds. It may take three hundred years. But it comes. It does not expire. It does not get cancelled. It does not arrive late.

When the young man finally crept into the city to buy food — what did he find? The society had embraced Islam. The very city that would have stoned them to death had they been caught — was now Muslim. The world had changed entirely while they slept.

While they were in the cave doing nothing visible — Allah was doing His work. While the Pharaoh sat in his palace thinking he had won — Allah was raising inside that same palace the one who would dismantle everything he had built.

Sometimes we overestimate our role. We think: if I am not actively doing something, nothing is happening. But Allah's plan does not depend on our visibility. We can be the means — or we can be observers — but the work belongs to Him.

CLOSING — THE CHOICE IS YOURS RIGHT NOW

The People of the Cave were not extraordinary in the way we usually think of the word. They were not scholars. They were not from wealthy or powerful families. They did not have armies or institutions or political influence behind them.

They were young people. In a hostile environment. Facing the same fundamental pressures that every young Muslim faces today — to conform, to compromise, to make yourself smaller, to stop being so visibly different.

And they made a series of choices that changed everything.

They chose their company deliberately — people whose goal was the face of Allah.

They focused on what mattered — the big lessons, not the small debates.

They understood the Quran — not as a book of beautiful sounds, but as a guide they were meant to follow.

They built their cave — a protected space where they could be fully themselves.

They stood firm without compromise — in front of the most powerful authority in their world.

They planned carefully — and trusted Allah completely.

And they took Allah as their closest companion — their Al-Wali — their hidden protector.

And in response to all of this — Allah tied their hearts together, redirected the sun around them for centuries, preserved their story in His eternal Book, and gave them a legacy that is being read, studied, and taught until this very day.

Your story is still being written.

The choices you make — about who you spend your time with, how you engage with the Quran, whether you build your cave or try to survive without one, where you draw your line and whether you hold it — these choices are writing your story right now.

Build your cave. Find your people. Know your Quran. Hold your line. And take Allah as your Al-Wali.

Because if you found Allah — you have everything.

La ilaha illallah. Allahu Akbar.

May Allah tie our hearts as He tied theirs. May He be our Al-Wali as He was theirs. May He make our children carry this deen with the same unshakeable confidence these young men carried it — in a world that tells them, every single day, to put it down.

Ameen.

ALL QURANIC VERSES — QUICK REFERENCE

Surah	Verse	Opening Words	Topic
Al-Kahf	18:10	إِذْ أَوَى الْفِتْيَةُ	Young men take refuge and make dua
Al-Kahf	18:11	فَضَرَبْنَا عَلَىٰ آذَانِهِمْ	Allah casts sleep over their ears
Al-Kahf	18:13	إِنَّهُمْ فِتْيَةٌ آمَنُوا	Young men who believed — Allah's introduction
Al-Kahf	18:14	رَبُّنَا رَبُّ السَّمَاوَاتِ	Their declaration before the king
Al-Kahf	18:16	فَأْوُوا إِلَى الْكَهْفِ	Take refuge in the cave
Al-Kahf	18:17	وَتَرَى الشَّمْسَ	Allah moves the sun away from their cave
Al-Kahf	18:19	فَابْعَثُوا أَحَدَكُم	Send one carefully — be alert, let no one know
Al-Kahf	18:20	إِنَّهُمْ إِن يَظْهَرُوا	If found — stoned or forced to apostate
Al-Kahf	18:21	وَكَذَٰلِكَ أَعْثَرْنَا	The promise of Allah is truth

Al-Kahf	18:22	سَيَقُولُونَ ثَلَاثَةٌ	Some say three, some say seven — stop arguing
Al-Kahf	18:22	قُل رَّبِّي أَعْلَمُ	Say: Allah knows best — move on
Al-Kahf	18:27	وَاتْلُ مَا أُوحِيَ	Tilawa means to follow, not just recite
Al-Kahf	18:28	وَاصْبِرْ نَفْسَكَ	Keep yourself with those who seek Allah's face
Aal-Imran	3:103	وَاعْتَصِمُوا بِحَبْلِ اللَّهِ	Hold to Allah's rope — do not be divided
Az-Zukhruf	43:67	الْأَخِلَّاءُ يَوْمَئِذٍ	Friends will be enemies on that Day — except the righteous
Al-A'raf	7:196	إِنَّ وَلِيِّيَ اللَّهُ	My protector is Allah — He protects the righteous
Al-Qasas	28:7	وَأَوْحَيْنَا إِلَىٰ أُمِّ مُوسَىٰ	Allah ties the heart of the mother of Musa
Ghafir	40:51	إِنَّا لَنَنصُرُ	Allah will support His messengers and believers

---

KEY HADITH

> *"The greatest jihad is to speak a word of truth to a tyrannical ruler."* — Sunan Abu Dawud (4344)

Based on the Surah Al-Kahf lecture series by Hisham Abu Yusuf | Al-Furqan Islamic Centre, Manchester